Building a Stylized Look



Final shot from the supplied breakdown video, extracted without on-screen titles.

A cinematic interpretation built for one shot

We developed a personal lighting, look development, and compositing study inspired by the scene of Zelda holding the decayed Master Sword. Our goal was to approach the visual qualities of the reference: warm skin, controlled shadows, golden hair with olive shadow areas, silver-cyan metal, and a turquoise sky that wrapped the character in light.

Scope of the work

We started with externally sourced base models and textures. Our work focused on pose and contact adjustments, look direction, materials, lighting, atmosphere, and compositing. The model presentation explains the asset used in the study; it does not claim credit for its original modeling.

The idea behind our decisions

The reference suggested that the resemblance depended more on shadow shapes, value hierarchy, and the separation of surface planes than on increasing texture complexity. We therefore organized the work around specific visual problems and checked every change through the final camera.

Read Before You Light



Cinematic reference. Nintendo.



Study result. Final framing and look of the shot.

Separating observation from implementation

We analyzed the image by region: face and neck, arms, hair, accessories, sword, and sky. We studied the size of the light and dark areas, the shadow edges, and the relative color temperature of each material. Those observations guided our Maya setup; we did not attempt to infer Nintendo's engine code from a screenshot.

A clear visual hierarchy

The center of the face needed to remain bright and serene. The side shadows had to fall asymmetrically: one reaches closer to the eye and temple, while the other leaves a larger area in the light. Under the jaw and along the collarbones, we aimed for readable shapes and prevented small shadows from merging into one heavy dark patch.

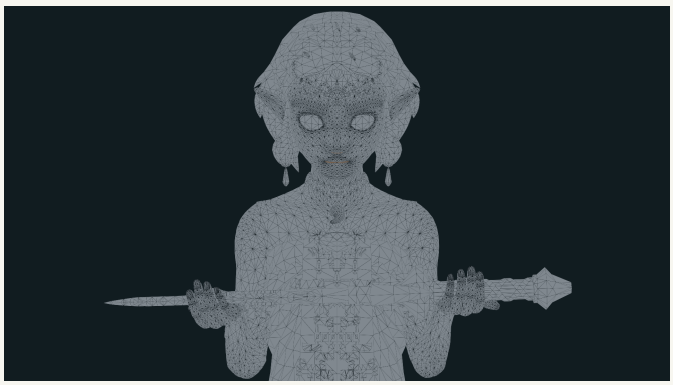
Warmth with color separation

The skin and main lights could be warm without turning the entire image yellow. We preserved their contrast with the cyan environment, the blue-violet tones of the sword hilt, and the greens of the costume. We adjusted color temperature per light and per material rather than relying entirely on a global filter.

Making the Support Believable



Corrected clay. Neutral eyes; diagnostic display +2 EV.



Topology of the original asset used in the study.

Establishing contact before polishing reflections

The pose needed to make the hands feel as though they were supporting the sword. We reviewed the relationship between the elbows, forearms, palms, and blade. The reference called for a delicate supporting gesture with relatively open fingers; curling them too far turned it into a rigid grip. We treated the contact points and the sword's orientation as constraints to preserve throughout the finishing work.

Locking approved decisions

Once we had approved the framing, gaze, elbows, and hand support, the later passes focused on shading and lighting. This kept us from evaluating composition, pose, and material changes all at once. Comparisons became clearer because the subject stayed in the same position within the frame.

A clay render that reveals form

The asset's eyes are built from separate layers. For the corrected clay render, we temporarily hid the irises, pupils, highlights, and eyelash cards, while keeping the eyeballs visible with the same neutral material as the rest of the character. The diagnostic view therefore shows form without the artificial contrast of colored eyes. The final render's geometry and materials are restored afterward.

Give Every Light a Purpose



Warm key light.



Ambient and fill.



Rim and artistic contour.

The shading base and the lighting are separate decisions

The NPR look includes shapes and tonal variations designed within the materials. A test with the physical lights switched off therefore retains part of the character's appearance. To explain the construction, we recorded an NPR base and enabled the lights cumulatively, keeping the camera, materials, and display exposure fixed.

Key, ambient, and fill

The warm key light establishes a coherent direction. The blue ambient fill keeps the shadows open, while the cream fill preserves a gentle treatment of the face and torso. Our goal was to support the form without erasing the separation between the lit areas and the areas in shadow.

Rim lighting and local support

The golden backlight and artistic contour help separate the shoulders, ears, and hair from the sky. The arms have dedicated bounce and specular support lights. In the final pass, we moderated the width and strength of the shoulder rim to retain a narrow edge of light without turning the forearms into a uniformly bright band.

What the video represents

The light build is a reconstruction of the final v40 scene to explain the function of its lights, rather than a historical record of every version. Physical light contributions are shown separately from the shader's designed highlights and shadows.

Ten Surface Light Sources

The final scene contains 16 lights: 11 active and 5 disabled. Ten active lights contribute to surfaces, while one is dedicated to the volume. The disabled lights remain in the scene, but they are not presented as contributors to the final result.

CONTROL / NAME	FUNCTION	TYPE
Source_Key	Warm key	Directional
Source_Neutral_Fill	Blue ambient fill	Skydome
Cinematic_Cream_Fill	Cream fill	Area
Source_Golden_Rim	Golden backlight	Directional
ArtistLight_SolarContour	Artistic contour	Directional
V17_InnerArmBounce	Inner arm bounce	Area
V24_ArmSatinCard	Skin satin response	Area / specular
V24_SwordReflectionCard	Sword reflection support	Area / specular
V27_BladeSecondaryStrip	Secondary blade reflection	Area / specular
V27_BladeReflectionStrip	Main blade highlight	Area / specular
V38_Atmosphere_Sun	Volume-only light	Spot / volume

Separating contributions for review

We assigned temporary light groups and exported individual source contributions from Arnold. We delivered one set at a shared exposure and another for diagnostic viewing, with each exposure increase labeled. The diagnostic images help identify subtle contributions, while the cumulative sequence allows us to judge their relative strength within the complete look.

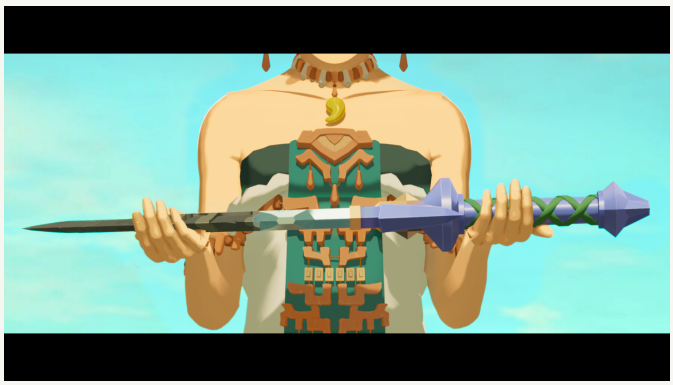
Lighting the blade

We developed the Master Sword's highlight by designing its shape through the reflection card's orientation, the light source's size, and the material response. The main card contributes only to the specular component; it does not add diffuse illumination to the character or illuminate the volume. This separation allowed us to adjust the metal without changing the skin or sky.

Designing Contrast by Plane



Hair: broad groups of color and highlights.



Sword: clean metal, corruption, hilt, and wrap.

Face, neck, and arms

We used NPR shading and control networks to design tonal bands, boundaries, and short transitions. We adjusted the neck and collarbone shadows locally, controlling their width and endpoints. We evaluated the solution through the final camera: a shadow can look convincing in a material test yet feel too heavy when the image is reduced to presentation size.

Hair: broad contrast before fine detail

We preserved the gold and olive areas, grouped the midtones, and reduced the fine variations that fragmented the crown. We organized the highlights into gold and cream layers with a narrow core. During the final refinement, we slightly broadened existing groups and reduced the brightest core to avoid disconnected white spots and a plastic appearance.

The sword: distinct responses for each region

We worked with the original textures and UVs. The clean metal needed a silver-cyan appearance and a continuous reflection; the corruption had to remain dark and rough. The guard and pommel retained lavender upper planes and violet lower planes. The green wrap remained mostly matte. A uniform correction across the entire sword would have blurred these material identities.

Keeping the reflection from overpowering the texture

We adjusted the card and roughness before increasing the light output. We also moderated reflections on the clean metal's lower planes and bevels. Our approval criterion was to preserve detail around the main highlight and maintain clear separation between planes, without turning the edge into a featureless white surface.

Integrating Without Losing Detail

Reference	**Pose & Camera**	**NPR Look Development**
Lighting & Reflections	**EXR / ACEScg**	**Nuke / Output**

A linear pipeline

We exported EXRs from Maya and processed the intermediate files in ACEScg. We applied the ACES 1.0 SDR-video view for an sRGB display only once when generating presentation images. The PNGs already include that display transform, while the EXRs retain their linear values for further adjustments.

Integrating the character with the sky

We separated the foreground from the background and the volume. In Nuke, we composited the CG over a sky plate extracted and reconstructed from the reference. The plate is prepared for this framing, with its central area covered by the character. When rebuilding the comp from the 4K render, we restricted the atmospheric residual to the foreground to prevent the Maya sky pattern from contaminating the soft plate.

Grading by material and protecting the eyes

We applied selective adjustments to the skin, hair, costume, and sword using region and color masks. In the eyes, we enhanced the existing irises and highlights while preserving the pupils as dark anchors. We confined the LightWrap to edge regions such as the head, ears, and shoulders; it did not replace contact shadows or the model's lighting.

Diffusion at two scales

We treated the hair and blade in separate branches. The hair can support broader localized diffusion, while the sword reflection needs a restrained halo to continue reading as metal. We tested soft, medium, and strong intensities and selected medium as the balance between integration, contrast, and detail. The main atmosphere comes from the rendered volume, avoiding an additional layer of global 2D fog.

Test, Compare, Preserve



Maya beauty before final integration.



Final shot: soft sky, grading, and localized diffusion.

Comparing with a specific question in mind

Each test answered a question: whether the side shadow reached too far across the eye, whether the collarbone looked like a groove, whether the hair was losing contrast, or whether the reflection obscured the metal. We compared the full shot with close-ups of the face, arms, and sword. We kept a local change only when it also worked within the shot's visual hierarchy.

Placing render quality where it matters

We used Arnold on CPU inside Maya. The final export included the beauty and foreground with AOVs at 3840 x 2160. We adjusted adaptive sampling and specular samples to improve edges and reflections. Increasing every sample setting at once, especially the volume samples, significantly increased render cost, so we reviewed those controls separately.

Different deliverables for different uses

We retained the Maya master as a linear EXR and a 16-bit PNG. The final comp and breakdown frames are 1920 x 1080, within the output format supported by the Nuke Non-Commercial version used on the project. The native .nknc projects are organized into stages linked through EXR intermediates.

Verifying scene preservation

Before and after the temporary passes, we compared the camera, transforms, geometry, UVs, deformation, assignments, and restored connections. We also checked the scene file using a hash. We reviewed the images for dimensions, content, and edit order. The clay views and light groups are temporary diagnostics; they do not require overwriting the approved v40 scene.

Building the Look Together

The resemblance emerges from organizing the image

Our main conclusion was that approaching the style required coordinating several small decisions: the shadow shape, highlight size, contrast between planes, hand contact, and the relationship between the character and the sky. A larger texture or stronger bloom could not resolve those relationships on its own.

Lighting works best when every contribution has a purpose

Separating the key, ambient, fill, rim, arm support, sword cards, and volume made it easier to correct one region without weakening another. The distinction between physical contributions and graphic layers was especially important: it lets us explain precisely what the lighting contributes and what is designed within the material.

Result and scope

The result is a stylized interpretation of a specific reference, prepared for a fixed shot. The face, neck, and reflection masks are designed for this pose and framing. The base geometry and texture resolution still limit the available detail. Extending the work to an animated sequence would require validating the stability of those masks and reflections across other poses and angles.

Credits

Zelda and The Legend of Zelda are owned by Nintendo. The base models and textures come from external assets. Work presented: pose and contact adjustments, lighting, look development, and compositing. This is a personal fan art study with no official affiliation. The specific asset author or distributor should be credited once their identity is established with certainty.

Renderer: Arnold 7.4.4.2. DCC: Maya 2026.3.3. Compositing: Nuke 17.1v1 Non-Commercial. Color management: ACEScg working space, with sRGB presentation output.

Study sources: Maya scene v40, comp v06, and portfolio exports. The light build was reconstructed from the approved scene to explain its functions. The closing still was extracted from the supplied breakdown video.

Final Shot



Clean closing frame from the supplied breakdown video. Maya / Arnold / Nuke.